robust and efficient. The Reserve Bank is the central bank—that is, it is the bank of banks, and the bank for the Central government as well as state governments. On top of all this, and importantly, the Reserve Bank has a key role in the economic development of the country and drives an impressive social development agenda.

That, in a nutshell, is the range and diversity of responsibilities of the Reserve Bank. And what it does affects the everyday lives of people across the country—from the prices they pay in the market, the interest they earn on their bank deposits, the interest they pay when they borrow from a bank, like, say the size of the EMI (equated monthly instalment) they pay on a house loan. It affects how much foreign exchange they can take out to spend or invest outside the country, say, for medical treatment or to educate a child abroad, and how the government pays for new roads, schools and hospitals.

My view was that if the Reserve Bank had to be held to account, we needed to demystify the institution so that the larger public understood what it did and how that connected to their lives.

There was another equally important motivation for my wanting to demystify the Reserve Bank. Not only do people not know what the Reserve Bank does, but they also have negative perceptions of the institution. A widely held stereotypical view of the Reserve Bank is of a rigid, wooden-headed monolith, making rules and regulations with little understanding of the realities of India.

I have personal experience of this negative stereotypical view of the Reserve Bank and how it becomes the scapegoat for virtually all maladies in the financial sector.

My first posting in the IAS after I completed training was as subcollector of Parvathipuram division in Srikakulam district of Andhra Pradesh. Those with long enough memory will recall that the tribal belt of north coastal Andhra Pradesh, particularly the tribal belt of Srikakulam district, was the first region outside of Naxalbari in West Bengal to come under the hold of the Naxalite movement in the late 1960s. By the time I went to